forced the imperial stallions ‘to swim like hippopotami’ through it. It was a slow, inching progress, and somewhere along the way, Akbar lost patience. There are endless accounts of Akbar doing this in the annals – if there is one thing he couldn’t bear, it seems, it was a sedate pace. Leaving the main camp by some meadows where his animals feasted on ‘fresh and moist grass’, Akbar galloped ahead. He had reached Dhar, barely 40 kilometres from Mandu where Abdullah governed, when he heard that the Uzbek chief had not greeted news of Akbar’s arrival with any great joy; in fact, he had fled the city at night.

Over the next few rain-drenched days and nights, Akbar’s men would chase Abdullah Khan westwards until the Uzbek abandoned his possessions and most of his family, escaping to Gujarat with his young son. Akbar rode against Abdullah himself, against the advice of one of his chiefs, Khaksar Sultan, who suggested, unwisely, that Akbar hang back a little from the front lines. Akbar was incensed, so much so that the terrified Khaksar Sultan leapt off his horse and ran for his life, ducking and feinting his way between a maze of horses’ legs. Not to be outdone, Akbar got off his horse too, chased the chieftain down and hit him with his sword – a doubled-edged ‘khanda’ blade, long used in Indian warfare, that did not, fortunately, kill the wretched man.

Others, too, tried to stop him as the arrows flew thick and fast, one right past Akbar’s head. Munim Khan suggested ‘in a despairing voice’ that they wait for reinforcements; another courtier even grabbed Akbar’s reins. The padishah paid no attention to either.

He knew what he was doing. Just as a general’s fall could destroy his army’s morale, so the sight of a king riding into battle could trounce his enemy. So it was now – Abdullah Khan and his men, though they numbered over 1000, fled before 300 under Akbar’s command. On 10 August 1564, Akbar marched in triumph into the citadel of Mandu.

Two months later, he was back in Agra, having ridden much of the way on musth elephants, including one particularly bad-tempered beast called Khandi Rai. If Akbar was seeking God’s opinion on his handling of the Abdullah affair, God must have approved, because Akbar survived his ride on the mad animal, driving the sharp point of one goad into his head, and striking him with another. In the long term, God was right: Akbar’s march against Abdullah was to the padishah’s advantage. In the immediate future,